

and Bach started looking for an alternative post and a new challenge. In 1723, a vacancy appeared in the Saxon city of Leipzig, a thriving center of commerce and culture. A “cantor” was needed, who would be responsible for the music in the Thomaskirche and other major churches in the city. Having failed to recruit their desired candidate, the prominent composer Georg Philipp Telemann, the city authorities reluctantly took on Bach—as one councilor put it, “when the best man cannot be obtained, mediocre ones have to be accepted.” Bach had to promise that his music would “not last too long,” nor be “operatic” in style. Despite this unpromising beginning, Bach had found a post he was to fill for the rest of his life.

“ The **sole end** and **aim** of **all music** should be the **glory of God** and the **recreation of the mind.** ”

J.S. BACH

Bach’s creative energy in his early years in Leipzig was astonishing. Responsible for the music at four churches, he wrote new cantatas at an average rate of one a week, plus larger-scale works for the high points of the church year—the Magnificat for Christmas 1723, the St. John Passion for Easter 1724, and the St. Matthew Passion for Easter 1727. Nor was his output by any means restricted to sacred music. Some of his best-loved keyboard pieces, including the Partitas, English Suites, and